

Handset

Problem with buying a phone is, there are waaay too many of them. We've reviewed 21 of them worth your attention

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Thirteen years after the GSM mobile revolution started in India, the scenario is such that landlines have been outnumbered by mobile phones. The youth drives India's mobile phone industry: around colleges are where you find the widest varieties of mobile phones. In addition, young people are most likely to buy new phones on a regular basis; they're also more likely to want features like music capabilities and cameras on their mobiles.

Taking into account the various usage patterns, mobile manufacturers are increasingly tending to divide their line-up of models into appropriate categories. We have the monochrome, plain ones (the last of their kind), which are meant to be just a means of communication. Then there are camera phones and phones with music playing capabilities, FM radio, and more. "Multimedia" phones emphasise the camera and media capabilities, so much so that certain vendors have started using the brand names of their media players and camera line-ups for their phones. Then there are PDA (Personal Digital Assistants) phones which are actually mini-computers, meant for business executives. What are called "smartphones" are packed to the brim with features. The last two categories are the most expensive.

Our last cell phone test was about a year ago. In this month's test, we tested GSM mobile phones priced up to Rs 17,000. The

business and lifestyle phone segments were therefore left out—we intend to review these soon. Twenty-one phones from six brands we reviewed for this test, and divided these into three categories based on price:

1. The Upper Crest (Rs 10,000–17,000)
2. Talk And Click (Rs 6,000–10,000)
3. Just A Phone (below Rs 6,000)

It might irk you that we didn't review many phones from some leading brands. This was because we wanted to give you the bigger picture on the new brands that have entered the market, and which might just displace the current leaders.

THE UPPER CREST

These are multimedia phones—much more than "just a phone." They are typically priced above Rs 10,000. Phones in this category were the Sony Ericsson (SE) CyberShot K550i, SE's hot new entrant in the market, as well as the SE Walkman W710i, which has been around for a few months. The Nokia 3250 XpressMusic, Nokia 5300, as well as the Nokia 6131 were some of Nokia's offerings that figured. The Motorola MotoKRZR K1, which flaunts looks similar to the hugely-successful MotoRAZR, also comes in this category.

Features Design and ergonomics

When you use a cell phone for long durations, ergonomics do matter. We reviewed three clamshells, two candybars, and one slider.